

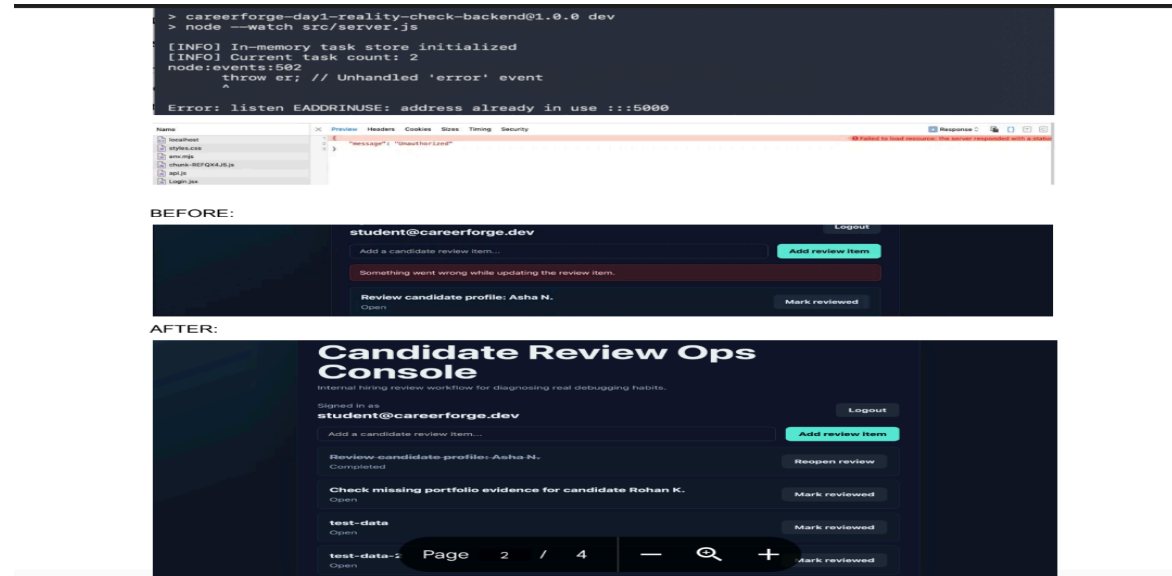
# Engineering Judgment Snapshot

Student: Alia Islam

## Strongest Capability:

Day - 01:

Debugging Investigation



I personally think this challenge was my strongest one. I was able to quickly identify the issues in the files provided and work through them efficiently. Debugging was something completely new to me, but I ended up really enjoying it. It felt exciting rather than intimidating, and this task was surprisingly the easiest for me to complete.

## Weakest Capability:

DAY 5

Choosing between the different options was genuinely challenging because I've always approached AI as if it's "always correct." This task forced me to question that assumption and think critically instead of accepting every suggestion at face value. Although it was the hardest challenge for me this week, it was also one of the most interesting. By the end, I felt much more confident making decisions based on my own reasoning rather than relying entirely on AI.

Here's the example:

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CareerForge Day 5: AI Is Not The Engineer

NAME: Alia Islam  
VARIANT: D5-A  
GITHUB: <https://github.com/liacodes49/Career-Forge/tree/day-05-ai-is-not-the-engineer>

### WHY I DID NOT BLINDLY FOLLOW THE AI

AI systems produced technically plausible recommendations. However, plausibility is not proof. Every recommendation was evaluated on three criteria:

- Is the evidence behind this claim independently verifiable?
- Does this action carry reversible or irreversible consequences?
- What is the failure mode if the AI's assumption is wrong?

### WHAT I TRUSTED

The root cause diagnosis (memory leak / OOMKilled) was supported by observable data, pod logs and Prometheus alerts are independent sources. This was treated as a credible hypothesis, not a confirmed fact, but worth acting on as a first investigation step.

The maxPoolSize configuration recommendation is consistent with well-established DB connection management patterns. The value of 10 is a reasonable starting point, not inherently dangerous, and testable in staging.

## Repeated Behavioral Pattern:

Across this week, I noticed that I tend to:

Enjoy finding and fixing errors so much that I start looking for problems even where there aren't any. At one point, I kept searching for more issues until something that was already working ended up breaking because I overanalyzed it.

## AI-Era Strength:

When using or judging AI, I am strongest at:

After completing Day 5, I think one of my strengths is evaluating debugging suggestions made by AI. While it occasionally misled me, it also provided genuinely useful insights. The experience taught me that AI is a powerful tool, but not always perfect. I now have a much better sense of what to trust, what to verify, and when to rely on my own judgment.

## Growth Gap:

The engineering habit I need to build next:

Building backend projects and debugging them myself, even while vibe coding with AI.

## Honest Self-Observation:

Complete:

Under pressure, I tend to look **for more errors and issues when they don't even exist.**

I need to improve **my timeliness whilst debugging.**

## 30-Day Commitment:

For the next 30 days, I will practice:

- I want to build a variety of projects that naturally involve debugging and challenge myself to solve the issues independently, just like I did during CareerForge.
- I want to let AI suggest approaches and decisions, then critically evaluate those suggestions and choose what I believe is the best solution instead of accepting them automatically.